

EDITORIAL

On Ambiguity, Contradiction and Paradox in Gendered Organizations

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As knowledge of gender relations in and around organizations increases and intensifies, it is perhaps not so surprising that there is increasing recognition of the complexity of those relations.

This is partly a question of gender relations meaning or referring to more than one thing. For example, gender might be interpreted in terms of gendered communication, gendered authority, relations between girls and boys, violence, sexuality, as well as various permutations amongst these and other elements. Indeed a special mention should be made of the interrelation of gender and sexuality, and the variety of ways that gender may imply, and yet not be the same as, sexuality, and vice versa.

Gender relations may also operate differently in different parts of the same organization, or in different organizations which may or may not be linked to each other. Another source of complexity is the intersection of gender relations with other social relations, most obviously those of economic class, ethnicity and race (see *Organization* 1996), but also other social divisions and social differences.

This attention to multiple social divisions highlights a number of possibilities: the focus on gender understood as a primary determining social division; the analysis of more than one social division at the same time; the construction of particular social divisions, such as economic class, through other social divisions, such as gender; and even the dissolution of categorical social divisions through such multiplicity. In all of these cases, complexity, that is gendered complexity, appears to exist through the intersection of gendered differences. It goes without saying that there are a number of different ways of making sense of these complexities.

This Special Issue addresses these concerns. It arises from the twelfth EGOS (European Group for Organizational Studies) Colloquium that was held from 6–8 July 1995 in Istanbul, hosted and sponsored by the Faculty of

Economics and Administrative Sciences, Bogaziçi University. The overall theme of the conference was, 'Contrasts and Contradictions in Organization', and these papers derive from among those presented at the sub-theme on 'Women, Men and Organizations: Contrasts and Contradictions'.

During the three days of the sub-theme 22 papers were presented with 25 regular participants from 11 countries. The starting point of the discussions was the acknowledgement of gender power relations in organizations, and beyond that presentations and discussions examined a number of contrasts and contradictions:

- between organizations managed by men and organizations managed by women;
- between women and men within organizations;
- between men and between women within organizations;
- between gendered processes in organizations in different societal cultures;
- between gendered power relations and other social divisions in organizations.

One of the simplest ways to talk of such gendered complexities is in terms of *ambiguity*: that differences arisen from or are understood in terms of the presence of two (or more) meanings. Gendered relations in organizations can thus be ambiguous — they may suggest both rigidity and stasis, on the one hand, and flexibility and change, on the other. A particular gendered situation, say, communication between peers, may have more than one meaning to the participants, either individually or more collectively. Ambiguity may also exist between actors' meanings and observers' meanings. In some instances, though not all, ambiguity of meaning may be associated with ambivalence on the part of one or more of those concerned. For example, managers may be ambivalent about delegating decisions to subordinates, and their ambivalence might be gendered in a number of ways with, for

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example, different forms of ambivalence in relation to women and men subordinates. At times it might be argued that too exclusive a focus on ambiguity and ambivalence might reduce wider structural (and poststructural) complexities to what might wrongly appear to be an autonomous realm of meaning.

A second more structurally based concept is that of *contradiction*. While contradiction literally means (two elements, people or arguments) speaking against (each other), its usage has often been extended to more systemic, structural or societal oppositions, antagonisms, conflicts or interests, whether latent or manifest. This is a parallel development to that of the word, *dialectics*, which has shifted from the Greek *dialectike* (the art of conversation, conversation with two speakers) to societal analyses often founded in materialism. Indeed Lenin (1961, pp. 359–60) defined dialectical materialism as that theory and practice founded upon '[t]he recognition of the contradictory, mutually exclusive, opposite tendencies in all phenomena and processes in nature ...', and dialectics as '... the study of the contradiction within the very essence of things'.

This approach to contradictions is most clearly expressed in the Marxist notions of class conflict, class struggle and class contradiction, and the so-called 'fundamental contradiction' of labour and capital. However, contradiction is also applied in various, more complex ways within Marxism and 'conflict sociology' (see, for example, Giddens 1973; Godelier 1973). Contradictions within economic classes, and between classes and intermediate classes; contradictions in the social practices of classes; contradictions between the interests of individual class members and collective class interests; contradictions between short-term and long-term interests, and between class-in-itself and class-for-itself; and contradictions in ideologies.

All of these notions of contradiction are profoundly relevant to the analysis of contradictions in gendered relations in organizations. At the most general and categorical level, there is the possibility of a fundamental contradiction between men and women, as in the notion of sex class or gender class (Firestone 1970; O'Brien 1981; Delphy 1984; Hearn 1987). Then there are the contradictions between different groups or collectivities of women and men, such as those defined by economic class. This in turn suggests possible contradictions between unities and differences, commonalities and diversities amongst women, and amongst men. Further contradictions may exist in gendered social practices and ideologies, for example, both marriage and employment can be simultaneously a means of

reproducing gendered material benefits and gendered exploitation and oppression. Overall, there could be said to be a variety of possible contradictions in 'gender systems', 'gender regimes', 'gender contracts', and 'gender orders'.

Thirdly, there is a concept of *paradox*, literally 'beyond belief'. This in some ways combines elements of linguistic meaning, as in ambiguity, and elements of social structure, as in contradiction. It brings together interpersonal interaction and oppositional structures in the form of social process, and specifically the possibility of impossibility. While the origins of the term lie in mathematics, logic and communication studies, paradox has been increasingly applied to the social more generally and to the organizational.

Paradox alerts us to the possibility that two things can occur that appear — perhaps at first, perhaps for a longer period, perhaps for all time — to be mutually exclusive. Matter may both exist and not exist; light can be both a stream of photons and a series of waves; a person can be both asleep and awake, even both alive and dead. Several simple and intriguing paradoxes are contained in the statement 'I am lying', and even more so in 'I always lie' (see Falletta 1983, pp. 75–86).

By itself paradox is neither negative nor positive (Pettegrew 1979). In communication studies and therapeutic interventions, some commentators have emphasized the negative, as in the 'double bind' theory of schizophrenia (Bateson *et al.* 1963), while others have argued for the use of contralogical messages in therapeutic change (Frankl 1960). Frequently these approaches point out the two levels present in communication — the message and the metamessage — and the paradox that may be between them (Watzlawick *et al.* 1967).

The concept of paradox has also been promoted in some postmodernist writing, emphasizing *différance*, that elusive combination of differing and deferring, of never fixed movement, and play of spacing within the text (Linstead and Grafton-Small 1992, p. 342). Interestingly, postmodernist contributions on paradox have often not attended to questions of gender. Indeed much postmodernism thinking continues to appear to be a way of men making absent the concerns of feminism and gender research.

A number of explicit attempts have been made to discuss paradox in the context of organizations and postmodernism. Linstead and Grafton-Small (1992) have argued that paradox and ambiguity are essential qualities of the supposedly 'shared meanings' of organizational culture: instead "'Shared Meaning" is nothing more than the deferral of Difference'

Table 1: *Ambiguity, contradiction and paradox*

	Disciplinary base	Focus	Main forms	Theory of power
<i>Ambiguity</i>	Linguistics, Action sociology	Personal and interpersonal meaning	Double meanings	Two-dimensional
<i>Contradiction</i>	Logic, Political economy, Structural sociology	Social structure	Opposition, Antagonism, Conflict	Three-dimensional
<i>Paradox</i>	Mathematics, Logic, Communication studies	Social process	Possibility of impossibility, <i>Différance</i>	All-pervasive

(p. 345). Discussions of paradox have also been connected with gender relations and gender construction (Lorber 1994; Gheradi 1995; Harlow and Hearn 1995).

The notion of paradox has also been important in my own work with Wendy Parkin on sexuality in organizations (Hearn and Parkin 1987/1995). Here part of the power of sexuality in organizations is furthered by the frequent construction of organizations as asexual. In some, often male-dominated, discourses, a situation or person can paradoxically become more sexual or more sexualized in the presence of asexual signifiers or asexual contexts.

Arguably, to foreground gendered paradox in organizations is to highlight the indeterminacy and provisional nature of organizational process and analysis.

Ambiguity, contradiction and paradox are three ways of analysing gendered complexities, and tensions in those complexities. They each address a rather different aspect of social reality — meaning, structure and process — and each emphasizes different forms of tension — dual meaning; opposition, antagonism and conflict; and the possibility of impossibility (see Table 1). However, this does not mean they are not compatible with each other. It is quite easy to see how a particular gendered social formation might simultaneously generate ambiguities, contradictions and paradoxes around the same cluster of tensions. Similarly, different social analysts may emphasize ambiguity, contradiction or paradox in making sense of the same social phenomena. Accordingly, each of these three concepts could be said to suggest a different theory of power. None of them are content with a single one-dimensional theory of power (Lukes 1974). Ambiguity is most easily related to a two-dimensional view emphasizing how non-decisions are also decisions; contradictions with a three-dimensional

structural view of interests; the paradox with a (four-dimensional?) view of power that constructs it as all-pervasive.

The four papers included here are all based on qualitative research studies, and they all in different ways explore particularly complex gendered processes. Qualitative studies are especially suited to the exploration of gendered complexities. They can assist the analyst in developing understandings of what may well be elusive meanings, structures and processes in organizations. Importantly, the process of research, research methods and methodology are also subject to gendered contradictions (Hsiung 1996, p. 124). These four articles are not just concerned with broad contrasts or general contradictions, but with specific and subtle forms of gendered complexity in gendered organizations.

In the first article, Yvonne Benschop and Hans Doorewaard draw on research into the Dutch banking sector to examine two classic concepts in organization theory — Taylorism and team-based work organization. Through case studies of two banking departments, they analyse a fundamental ambiguity between the agendered presentation of these forms of organization and the reproduction of the gender subtext and hierarchical gender distinction.

The three remaining articles all focus more specifically on the impact of organizational change on gender relations. Interestingly, all are based on Nordic case studies, and as such are set within the societal contradiction of the presence of relative gender equality (at least on most international measures) and the persistence of gender inequality. The first of these contributions is Päivi Korvajärvi's study of gendered change in a Finnish employment agency. A variety of contradictions in gendered hierarchies are examined, particularly with the introduction of more men as employment counsellors into the office. In making sense of this situation,

this article echoes many of the themes of the first article, such as the contradictions between formal rules and informal sociability, and between the invisibility and visibility of gender. It also attends to the detailed operation of contradictions at the level of the everyday work of the agency.

The second pair of articles is from Sweden. Elisabeth Sundin considers the contradictory impacts of the introduction of CAD technology in the Swedish National Land Survey on gendered work organization both within and outside the office. This basic change in technology has meant that the former patterns of manual survey work carried out by men 'in the field' and draughting work carried out by women have been transformed by new technology that does not rely on the immediate physical 'mastering' of the environment. This indirectly opens up new possibilities for gendered work organization in the office. Sundin analyses the complexities of gendered responses and indeed resistances to this change, and argues that questions of gendered space and place are in this case especially significant and probably more so than the gendered meaning of technology itself.

Finally, Ulla Johansson presents some of the results of ethnographic research into a Swedish housing agency. Again issues of gendered organizational change over time and gendered meanings of space, but in this case more local space, are explored. In particular, the study analyses the gendered complexities that follow the creation of generic caretakers, who perform all the work tasks in and around the housing units, in place of separate work tasks for women (for example, indoor cleaning) and for men (for example, outdoor cleaning and indoor repairs), that were thus organized in relation to local public/private space. The effects of this were multiple. While in some senses dualistic stereotypes were reproduced in this process, at the same time the effects of women taking up 'men's work' were very different to the reverse effects of men taking up 'women's work'. Furthermore, these effects themselves changed over time as workers became used to new gendered meanings of their work. To make sense of these complex changes, Johansson understands this gendered reality as paradoxical, and elucidates this by the use of narratives by not two but three genders.

These articles can themselves be understood in a number of ways. They may be seen as describing the subtleties of micro-organizational life that add interesting local detail to the broad picture of what are essentially macro-gendered power relations; or alternatively they may be thought of as presenting material that suggests a much more

fundamental rethinking of the nature and operation of those gendered power relations, and even of power itself. The paradox is that they are both.

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